

Inspection of Coventry local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 9 to 13 March 2026

Lead inspector: Sophie Wales, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Outstanding
Overall effectiveness	Outstanding

Children and care leavers in Coventry benefit from consistently good practice from practitioners who know them well. As a result, most children and young people make impressive progress. Most children and families now access help and support at a time and place that is right for them, which results in their needs being met at the earliest opportunity. As committed corporate parents, leaders have ensured sufficient provision for children in care. This means that more children can live locally and remain in the communities and schools they know, cared for by skilled and dedicated carers.

Political and corporate leaders, partners and local business leaders have been relentless in their determination for children in Coventry to succeed. They have ensured good decisions are made for, and with, children and care leavers. Innovation and creativity are central to leaders' ambition to strengthen outcomes for children. This can be seen in work to reunify children with their birth families when this is safe to do so, meaning more children can live at home with their parents. Strong practice to support children and care leavers to establish Lifelong Links means many children and young people now benefit from significant, long-lasting relationships with people who care about them.

Leaders know the quality and impact of services for children and young people. The limited areas for improvement in practice identified during this inspection were already known and being addressed by the local authority. Leaders have created a culture of trust, openness, challenge and belonging. This has enabled consistently good-quality practice to flourish across most of children's services. It has also stabilised the workforce, where morale is high.

What needs to improve?¹

- The consistency of the quality and impact of planning for children in need of help and protection. (outcome 2, national framework)
- The consistency of the quality and impact of supervision. (enabler 3, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children in Coventry who need help and protection receive prompt and effective support from practitioners who know them well. Children benefit from a range of early help services delivered through local family hubs. Comprehensive and detailed early help assessments ensure that children's voices are considered well, leading to purposeful, targeted support for families.
2. Concerns about children are appropriately referred to the multi-agency safeguarding hub (MASH) by partners. When contacts do not meet the threshold for statutory services, they are appropriately directed for early help support. Swift action is taken when concerns increase and a response is needed from the MASH.
3. Managers provide timely oversight and clear direction about contacts that come into the MASH. MASH social workers have 'Conversations with Families' when contacts are made. By seeking agreement to progress with screening, social workers build positive relationships with parents. When information must be shared without parental agreement, due to concerns about significant harm to children, this is appropriate and clearly documented.
4. Social workers ensure that family histories and previous agency involvement are considered to inform their decisions. Contacts conclude in a timely manner, meaning concerns about children are swiftly responded to. Risk to children forms part of the overall analysis and informs decisions about next steps.

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

5. The Emergency Duty Service (EDS) is effective in ensuring that children are appropriately safeguarded out of office hours. Risks to children are mostly explored through timely strategy meetings. Sometimes, the EDS is contacted without action being required as police have already taken protective steps to safeguard children without multi-agency involvement. Leaders are aware of this and continue to hold conversations with statutory partners about this practice. EDS ensures a seamless handover with day services, ensuring that appropriate ongoing action is taken.
6. When there are concerns about significant harm to children, strategy meetings are held promptly and include relevant professionals. Risks to children are understood well. Information shared enables appropriate and proportionate decision-making. Clear action plans, with appropriate timescales, are developed. When further social work involvement is needed, children are quickly allocated to social workers in area teams.
7. The majority of assessments are detailed and identify and understand children's needs well. Weaker assessments are too cursory in their analysis, meaning resulting plans for children do not always identify all appropriate actions. For a small number of children, there is a delay in local authority specialist assessments being completed. This means that some children wait too long before they receive a service that meets their needs and reduces risk.
8. Children in need practice is mostly effective. Well-written child in need plans are specific and timely. Children in need are supported by practitioners who have access to a range of resources. Child in need reviews are held regularly and are well attended, and impactful interventions are effective in reducing risk for children. Wider family and children's support networks are routinely considered in planning for children. For a small number of children in need, there is some delay in taking alternative action when plans are not having the desired impact on their experiences.
9. When children are at risk of harm, timely and detailed child protection enquiries provide a clear analysis and understanding of children's situations. Decisions to progress to child protection conferences are proportionate and appropriate. Children's wishes and feelings are sensitively gathered, and this ensures that social workers understand children's worries and concerns. Social workers demonstrate a thorough understanding of threshold to progress support when this is needed.
10. Initial child protection conferences are completed in a timely way and include relevant professionals. When children are at risk of harm, multi-agency plans are formulated to outline the help and support that children and families need from a wide range of services.
11. Most child protection plans are clear about risks to children. Review child protection conferences and core group meetings are held regularly and involve professionals working with the family. While these note progress in actions set

out in the child protection plan, they are not always sufficiently curious about the progress children are making, and as a result, the impact of practice for children is not always clear. This means that for a small minority of children who have experienced neglect for a prolonged period, plans are not effective in improving their experiences in a timely way.

12. Practitioner visits to children are purposeful and address the presenting risks, with the frequency of visiting increasing when required. Children are seen outside the home, allowing children a safe space to talk with people they trust. Children's records provide a comprehensive overview of the visits undertaken, with social workers outlining any progress or issues of concern. Safety plans are devised with children to help them to understand the risks they may face. Children and parents are sometimes offered advocates who can support them in meetings and to help them to understand the reasons for social care involvement.
13. Trusting relationships with parents lead to a greater understanding of the issues impacting on the care for the child. There is a strong focus on extended family networks and the support that can be provided for children. Family network meetings are held regularly, and family members are involved in developing children's plans. When alternative care is considered, assessments identify appropriate contingency planning.
14. When concerns for children increase, the pre-proceedings stage of the Public Law Outline (PLO) processes leads to a high number of children and families being well supported and diverted from care proceedings when this is safe to do so. Targeted interventions and high-quality assessments inform and support this process. Leaders ensure effective oversight of work undertaken in the PLO process, preventing drift in planning for children.
15. Feedback from the judiciary and the Children and Family Court Advisory and Support Service (Cafcass) describes highly effective practice with parents during proceedings, who are helped to understand what they need to do to ensure their children can remain with them. Strong practice in the Family Drug and Alcohol Court was particularly recognised by the judiciary.
16. When allegations are made against people who work with children, these are managed well in a timely way. Position of trust meetings are attended by a range of appropriate professionals, and plans are effective in addressing the concerns raised. This means that when there are concerns about adults, they are consistently followed through and children are appropriately safeguarded.
17. Children who live in private fostering arrangements are well supported. Timely and detailed assessments are completed of private foster carers. Social workers regularly visit children in private fostering arrangements. Children are included in decision-making meetings to ensure that their wishes and feelings are known. There is strong multi-agency partnership working that includes both carers and parents. Leaders have strengthened their oversight of children

subject to private fostering arrangements with ongoing awareness-raising across the partnership.

18. Children who are at risk of exploitation and of going missing are supported by skilled workers from an effective, well-coordinated service. The well-established Horizon team oversees a wide range of multi-agency interventions, diversionary activity and robust safety planning to keep children safe. Risks and push-and-pull factors are considered through a trauma lens, which supports families' own understanding of the reasons for their children's vulnerability, which is helping to keep them safer.
19. Earlier identification and effective interventions ensure that 16- and 17-year-old children at risk of homelessness are provided with effective support. Joint assessments are undertaken with housing colleagues, and family network meetings are used to maximise the support of the wider family to keep children living at home where possible. When needed, children are appropriately accommodated with longer-term plans developed. Leaders have strengthened their oversight of these arrangements since the last inspection.
20. Disabled children are supported by practitioners who develop meaningful relationships with them and understand their complex needs. Practitioners visit children regularly to seek their views, considering their bespoke communication needs. Visits to children are well written, detailing children's daily lived experiences. Parents' views are integral to thorough assessments and purposeful plans that meet children's needs.
21. Effective edge-of-care services support families to bring about positive change when children are at risk of coming into care. Building on family strengths and strong relationships, more children are able to stay living within the family, cared for by people who love them.
22. There are clear systems in place to identify and monitor children receiving elective home education and to respond if there are concerns about their welfare. The local authority offers appropriate challenge to families. The growing number of pupils who are electively home educated means that leaders have reduced capacity to retain oversight of the service to monitor trends and complete data analysis to inform strategic planning.
23. There are effective systems in place to identify and monitor children who are missing education. The authority takes a proactive approach to ensuring that these children are located and supported in re-engaging with educational opportunities. In the main, this is having a positive impact; however, this is less so for pupils with special educational needs and/or disabilities (SEND).

The experiences and progress of children in care: outstanding

24. When children can no longer stay at home safely, timely decisions are made for them to come into care. The vast majority of children live in loving, stable

homes that meet their needs. Local authority foster carers receive comprehensive training that helps them to understand children's needs well. Children and foster carers receive strong support from their social workers. Children living in the local authority's children's homes are well supported, and most are making progress in all aspects of their lives.

25. When children are in care, social workers complete timely and regular child and family assessments to ensure that care planning remains relevant and effective. Most children who are looked after in Coventry have plans to live in their 'forever' homes quickly progressed. Although some plans can vary in quality, strong senior leadership and independent reviewing officer (IRO) oversight ensures that plans are progressed at a speed that meets children's needs. A range of permanence options are considered for children, including living with extended family members or adoption. Senior leaders and IROs regularly review social work plans to ensure they continue to be timely and meet children's needs.
26. Children in care benefit from positive relationships with their workers, who know them well and want the best for them. Children are visited regularly, in keeping with their needs and wishes, and these visits have a clear purpose. Social workers regularly undertake direct work and life-story work with children. This helps children to understand their life history and the reasons why important decisions have been made. This high-quality practice enables social workers to form long-standing positive relationships with children. As a result, children in care flourish.
27. Children in care are involved in key decisions that will impact on their lives. Their views are sought through regular conversations with their social worker, IRO and in their reviews. Timely review meetings are attended by children and birth parents. IROs undertake midway reviews and are updated by social workers to keep them informed about children's progress. This ensures that for most children, their care plans continue to progress well.
28. There is strong ambition in Coventry to return children home from care whenever this is safe and possible. Thorough assessments are undertaken with parents to ensure that the risk to the child is well understood. Carefully considered, well-written multi-agency transition plans support children as they return home. Social workers undertake sensitive direct work to support the child's understanding of their history and their views about returning home. Ongoing support plans are comprehensive and regularly reviewed to ensure that the child's progress is monitored and that the professional group continues to be responsive to the child's needs.
29. Family network meetings consider extended family members caring for children if they cannot remain living with their parents. Kinship carers receive a high level of training and support from their social workers. This means that when possible and appropriate, children can remain living with their wider family, cared for by people who know their histories and who love them.

30. Most children in care are supported to understand their experiences and history through purposeful therapeutic life-story work and play therapy. This is contributing to children feeling settled and cared for and stabilises their long-term placements.
31. Children's physical and emotional health needs are met well through a comprehensive, wide-ranging offer of face-to-face and online support. When there are potential delays, such as assessments for neurodiversity, social workers take appropriate action to expedite processes. Health partners are an integral part of the planning process to ensure that social workers can navigate any barriers to services. More initial health assessments for children are now completed in appropriate timescales.
32. The virtual school provides effective and increasingly impactful support for children in care. Impressive leadership over the last year has led to strengthened oversight, inclusion and SEND provision, contributing to rising attendance, no permanent exclusions and a significant reduction in the use of part-time timetables. The quality of personal education plans is consistently high, with recent improvements ensuring clearer oversight, better targeted support and more robust tracking of progress. Most children make good progress from their starting points despite high levels of SEND. Post-16 practice is improving, with greatly increased engagement and clearer pathways for transition, although quality is still variable. Overall, the virtual school knows children in care in Coventry well, advocates strongly for their needs and provides support that is improving children's educational experiences and outcomes.
33. Children in care benefit from a wide range of social, educational and recreational opportunities, including football, dancing and music groups. Children enjoy holidays with their foster families and positive experiences at the local authority's well-loved outward-bound provision.
34. Children in care have family time that takes place at a frequency that is in children's best interests and that meets their needs. Family time is well planned and takes place in child-friendly settings. This helps children to retain important connections with people who are important to them while continuing to live in caring and safe environments. The embedding of Lifelong Links for most children supports them to establish and maintain relationships with people who are safe and important to them. This allows children to establish a network of positive role models who can support them in the future.
35. There is strong oversight and support for children who go missing from care. Sensitive work is completed with children who go missing and who are at risk of exploitation. Workers from the specialist missing and exploitation team, Horizon, work alongside social workers to complete comprehensive assessments and formulate plans to ensure that children are safer and risks are understood. After episodes of going missing, children are seen quickly and purposeful return home interviews are completed.

36. Disabled children in the care of the local authority live in stable placements that meet their complex needs. Social workers are strong advocates for children and are clear about the plans for their future.
37. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children receive effective help and support to meet their needs. Timely assessments are completed about children's age and their eligibility for care and support. These are sensitively completed and demonstrate social workers' significant expertise and knowledge base about the traumatic experiences of children. Decisions are made quickly about whether children should be accommodated. Well-developed plans address children's needs. Careful consideration is given to the homes children live in, often within easy access to colleges, leisure activities, friends and religious institutions, such as churches and mosques. Timely consideration is given to children's legal status to ensure they have the security needed to remain in the country, affording them more certainty about their futures.
38. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children are highly valued. For example, the national award-winning unaccompanied asylum-seeking social work team, with the support of charities and local businesses, has created a football team providing children with the opportunity to establish new peer relationships, a sense of belonging and to develop skills themselves in coaching and mentoring.
39. The right adoptive homes are found for children who need them. Thorough assessments and well-formulated plans lead to timely, well-considered matching decisions. Social workers visit children regularly in their new homes. A wide range of support is provided to ensure that adopters can provide the best possible care to children. Children's birth families are integral to planning for adoption. Siblings are placed together with adopters whenever this is possible and appropriate. Ongoing direct contact with siblings and birth parents takes place when it is in children's best interests. This means that children who are adopted can retain important links to their birth family.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: outstanding

40. When children transition to adult services, timely referrals ensure that plans are effective and well thought through. Personal advisers (PAs) are allocated with enough time to support children to build meaningful and lasting relationships to help them through this time of change.
41. Care leavers have positive, trusting and stable relationships with PAs. PAs are fierce advocates for young people, challenging practice and holding partner agencies to account. Plans change or are accelerated when needed because of this tenacious advocacy, resulting in tangible, positive differences for care leavers.
42. Aspirational pathway plans are co-developed with care leavers in sufficient time to support a successful transition to support children as they approach adulthood. Plans set out well how young people will be supported to achieve

their goals and hold professionals to account for actions they have agreed to take to support care leavers. Plans are dynamic and reviewed regularly, making them highly effective and purposeful. Pathway plans clearly set out care leavers' rights and entitlements.

43. PAs keep in touch with all care leavers through regular, purposeful visiting. PAs accompany young people to significant events and keep in touch regularly through a wide range of accessible formats to meet individual care leavers' needs. This supports care leavers to feel highly valued and cared for.
44. There is comprehensive support for care leavers over the age of 21 years if they choose to access this. Care leavers receive support for as long as is right for them. If care leavers choose to step away from direct support, PAs provide them with relevant information about accessing support in the future and write personalised farewell letters to the young people, referring to key moments in their lives. If care leavers need to come back to the service at any time for support, they are easily able to do so.
45. Care leavers are supported to maintain relationships with people who are important to them through the well-established Lifelong Links service. Almost all care leavers have benefited from this service and have built or strengthened relationships with people who are important to them.
46. Care leavers' physical, emotional and mental health needs are well met. This includes through online support, drop-in support and interventions from specialist mental health providers when this is needed. This is highly valued by care leavers. Care leavers also benefit from the emotional support provided to them by their PAs. Importantly, care leavers are supported to understand their health histories through their health passports, which are shared with them. When needed, PAs support care leavers to access sexual health services and to gain information to engage in safe relationships.
47. Care leavers benefit from a comprehensive, wide-ranging local offer that has been developed in partnership with them, regardless of where in the country they live. Being care experienced is now a protected characteristic in Coventry. This acts to address any potential disadvantage of having been in care and has made a tangible difference to some care leavers' lives. Care leavers have the use of a warm, welcoming hub where they receive targeted drop-in support and practical help for developing independent life skills, including learning how to cook and do laundry.
48. Vulnerable care leavers are well supported. PAs are provided with the skills and knowledge they need to identify and work sensitively with care leavers who are vulnerable to exploitation or other harm. Young parents or carers of younger siblings are encouraged and supported by their PAs. Those seeking employment as younger parents are advised well on childcare and supported to navigate the complex world of benefits and entitlements.

49. Care leavers are supported to develop independent living skills, including managing their own tenancies, finding work and support to manage their finances. Care leavers have access to a wide range of appropriate accommodation to meet their individual needs. Coventry's House Project is a strength, where care leavers have access to training flats and are given priority status for local authority housing provision. There have been no tenancy breakdowns for care leavers in their own accommodation via the House Project, such is the level and quality of support they receive.
50. Comprehensive assessments, taking account of any specific vulnerabilities, ensure that care leavers are matched with suitable supported accommodation. Strong oversight of care leavers in these arrangements ensures that the support provided to care leavers is of a very high quality.
51. 'Staying put' and 'staying close' arrangements are maturely developed in Coventry. A culture of belonging has been developed in the service where care leavers feel valued and cared for, and where care leavers are encouraged to remain in touch with people who know and care about them.
52. Coventry has a strong, joined-up system to help care leavers move into education, training and employment. Specialist employment, education and training (EET) PAs ensure a wide range of education and employment support is provided through the successful Coventry Job Shop. PAs support care leavers to be ambitious and aspirational about their education and employment choices. An EET multi-agency panel provides information, advice and guidance to care leavers with offers of apprenticeships and other EET opportunities. The House Project offers additional drop-in support for care leavers to find out about these opportunities. Social care leaders work closely with others in the local authority and a range of local partners to provide work experience opportunities for care leavers, including apprenticeships. This helps care leavers progress well into adulthood.
53. When young people are not in EET, PAs are determined in their efforts to overcome barriers young people may face to help them engage in purposeful learning opportunities.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

54. Impressive, outward-looking leaders have demonstrated an unwavering ambition and commitment to children in Coventry. They have continued to strengthen the quality and impact of services, despite considerable external challenges of the number of children living in poverty and a significant rise in demand for services. Highly effective strategic partner relationships have ensured this success. Partners, local businesses, colleagues, families and children all benefit from the Family Valued relational practice model, which continues to embed across the city. By building lasting relationships, Lifelong Links is now ensuring more children in care and care leavers have someone

they can depend on and turn to for support. Leaders have embraced this approach, with many leaders and workers themselves providing lasting support to children.

55. The experiences of children in Coventry continue to improve. More children and families now access help and support at a time and place that is right for them. This means fewer children are subject to statutory processes. More children now live in homes with people who know them and love them, and the most vulnerable children in care are increasingly accessing and engaging in education as a result of transformative leadership in the virtual school.
56. Leaders have worked with children and local businesses to make Coventry a child-friendly city. The 'Child Friendly Cov' campaign seeks the views of children and young people to build a community that makes Coventry a good place to live and grow. This includes the safe space initiative across the city, where children can go to feel safe.
57. Building on existing strong foundations, leaders are making steady progress in the implementation of the children's social care reforms through the Families First Partnership Programme.
58. Leaders understand the quality and impact of practice with children and families. Through a wide range of quality assurance and performance activity, social work practice remains consistently good for most children. Leaders use performance data effectively, though more needs to be done to strengthen the impact of audit activity. Since the ILACS inspection in 2022, leaders have successfully addressed most areas for improvement. Areas of practice that need strengthening are known and being acted on by leaders.
59. Leaders recognise the importance of children living close to home and in communities they identify with. As a result of targeted work to increase sufficiency, there is now a wider range of placements available when children cannot remain living at home. This is also leading to greater placement stability for children in care. No children in care currently live in unregistered care provision.
60. Progress for children in care is reviewed and monitored through a highly effective corporate parenting board. Children and young people are active members of the board. As a result, children and young people strongly influence decisions made for and with them.
61. Importantly, leaders have significantly strengthened their approach to equality, identity and diversity, and practice and attitudes are tangibly changing as a result. As adopters of the Race Equality Code, leaders have embraced diversity and adopted a clear anti-racist position. This is actively leading to a greater sense of inclusion and belonging across the workforce and bringing a sharpened focus on children's identity to workers' practice.

62. By creating a culture of belonging, leaders have done much to strengthen the workforce in Coventry. Through a comprehensive workforce strategy and offer to workers, there is a reducing reliance on temporary workers. This means children are benefiting from longer and more purposeful relationships with people who know them and who are committed to their progress. Social workers spoke positively of working in Coventry. The leadership team is reported to be visible and approachable.
63. Management oversight of frontline practice is mostly effective in providing case direction. Supervision takes place regularly, and workers value the reflective opportunity this provides them. The quality and impact of supervision remain variable across most parts of the service. In some areas of practice, other processes for management oversight mitigate the impact on children of this variability.
64. Leaders ensure that workers benefit from a wide range of impactful training and development opportunities delivered in a variety of accessible formats. The comprehensive training offer and opportunities to progress and develop are contributing to staff stability and motivation to work in Coventry. Leaders have created sufficient capacity across the teams to ensure that workloads are manageable.

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